

» BADMINTON NATIONAL CHAMPIONSHIP

Taking the next step: The 16-year-old Anmol Kharb — ranked No. 1 in both U-17 and U-19 in singles — will focus on the senior category next year.

RITU RAJ KONWAR

YOUNG GUNS MAKE THEIR MARK AND GIVE GLIMPSE OF BRIGHT FUTURE

There's a **concern** about the lack of successors in Indian women's badminton after Saina Nehwal and P. V. Sindhu. But the future looks tall.

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In the 85th edition of the Senior National Badminton Championships at the Deshbhakta Tarun Ram Phookan Indoor Stadium in Guwahati, Anmol Kharb from Haryana grabbed the spotlight. At 16 years and 11 months old, she secured the women's national championship title by defeating 15-year-old Tanvi Sharma from Punjab 15-21, 21-17, 16-8 (retd.) in the final.

When Saina Nehwal clinched the Senior National Women's Singles title in 2006-07 in Patna, she was 16 years and 10 months old. When P.V. Sindhu bagged the women's crown in 2011-12 in Bengaluru, she was 16 years and six months old. In badminton circles, there's a concern

about the lack of successors in Indian women's badminton after Saina and Sindhu. Can Anmol and Tanvi follow in their footsteps internationally? With their talent and skills, they have the potential. The key lies in transitioning from juniors to seniors.

For perspective, Anmol and Tanvi are the best juniors in India in both Under-17 and Under-19. Tanvi is behind Anmol at No. 2 in both categories. On the other hand, Tanvi has done a tad better than Anmol at the international level. Tanvi bagged the silver medal in the Asian U-17 championships in October 2023, while Anmol lost in the first round of the same tournament.

As far as junior world rankings go, Tanvi stands at 112, while Anmol is at 121. In the BWF senior rankings, Anmol is 470 in women's singles and Tanvi is 586.

Anmol and Tanvi haven't featured

in too many international tournaments. Anmol just played the Chhattisgarh International Challenge in Raipur in 2023, where she reached the round of 16 after playing two qualifying rounds. Tanvi competed in a singles event and three doubles competitions. In the only singles tournament — the Chhattisgarh International Challenge in 2023 — Tanvi reached the round of 32. Tanvi paired with her elder sister Radhika Sharma in doubles at the Guwahati Masters (round of 16) and Syed Modi International, where the duo lost in the qualifying. It was in the Chhattisgarh International Challenge that the sister pair reached a creditable quarterfinal.

Sanjiv Sachdeva, a former India junior coach and current member of the Indian junior team selection committee, has observed Anmol's performance in the Krishna Khaitan